

After Twenty Years

O. Henry · 1906

First published: New York Sunday World, 1906; The Four Million

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay
Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: Claude Monet, The Magpie (1868–1869). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Four_Million/After_Twenty_Years (revision 14234467), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 6–9 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does After Twenty Years suggest about loyalty and duty?
- What does After Twenty Years suggest about change over time?
- What does After Twenty Years suggest about friendship?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	After Twenty Years	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*loyalty and duty* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: After Twenty Years

Focus: friendship tested by duty

Content note (): No significant sensitive content flagged; preview as usual.
Student preview: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

A man waits in a New York doorway to meet his old friend Jimmy Wells, twenty years to the day after they parted. He tells a patrolling policeman about the plan. A man claiming to be Jimmy arrives, but he is a plainclothes officer who arrests the waiting man, 'Silky' Bob, wanted in Chicago. A note reveals that the patrolman was Jimmy, who recognized Bob as the wanted man and could not arrest him himself.

Background: Published in 1906 and collected in The Four Million, which names the ordinary New Yorkers O. Henry wrote about.

Significance: A compact surprise ending that rewards rereading for planted clues.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: Would you turn in a friend who had done something seriously wrong? Why or why not? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are submerged, corresponded, egotism, unfolded, vicinity. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "The other, submerged in his overcoat, listened with interest." In this sentence it means: sink below the surface; go under or as if under water. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of After Twenty Years would have known. Published in 1906 and collected in The Four Million, which names the ordinary New Yorkers O. Henry wrote about. Why does this story matter? A compact surprise ending that rewards rereading for planted clues. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for irony.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "THE policeman on the beat moved up the avenue impressively." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to friendship tested by duty? I circle "impressively", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find irony, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for irony.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of irony. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *THE policeman on the beat moved up the avenue impressively. The impressiveness was habitual and not for show, for spectators were few. The time was barely 10 o'clock at night, but chilly gusts of wind with a taste of rain in them had well nigh depeopled the streets.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Irony, Foreshadowing, Characterization: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how After Twenty Years develops the idea of friendship tested by duty. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to loyalty and duty? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about friendship tested by duty, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how irony shapes friendship tested by duty. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
submerged (verb)	sink below the surface; go under or as if under water	*The other, submerged in his overcoat, listened with interest.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
corresponded (verb)	exchanged letters	*"Well, yes, for a time we corresponded," said the other.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
egotism (noun)	too much concern with oneself	*The man from the West, his egotism enlarged by success, was beginning to outline the history of his career.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
unfolded (verb)	explained; revealed	*The man from the West unfolded the little piece cf paper handed him.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
vicinity (noun)	a surrounding or nearby region	*The vicinity was one that kept early hours.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
dismally (adverb)	in a gloomy, depressing way	*The few foot passengers astir in that quarter hurried dismally and silently along with coat collars turned high and pocketed hands.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
doubtfully (adverb)	in an uncertain or unsure way	*"Is that you, Bob?" he asked, doubtfully.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
impressively (adverb)	in a way that commands notice or respect	*THE policeman on the beat moved up the avenue impressively.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Would you turn in a friend who had done something seriously wrong? Why or why not?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with loyalty and duty?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How long ago did the two friends agree to meet? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Twenty years
2. Where is the waiting man from now? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: The West, Chicago

3. What clue shows the waiting man's wealth? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A diamond scarfpin and watch
4. Who was the patrolling policeman? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Jimmy Wells
5. Why did Jimmy send someone else to make the arrest? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He could not bring himself to arrest his old friend
6. Retell the three most important events of "After Twenty Years" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A man waits in a New York doorway to meet his old friend Jimmy Wells, twenty years to the day after they parted. He tells a patrolling policeman about the plan. A man claiming to be Jimmy arrives, but he is a plainclothes officer who arrests the waiting man, 'Silky' Bob, wanted in Chicago. A note reveals that the patrolman was Jimmy, who recognized Bob as the wanted man and could not arrest him…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "After Twenty Years"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "After Twenty Years" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "The other, submerged in his overcoat, listened with interest." What does "submerged" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: submerged: sink below the surface; go under or as if under water.
10. Reread: ""Well, yes, for a time we corresponded," said the other." What does "corresponded" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: corresponded: exchanged letters.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "After Twenty Years" suggest about friendship tested by duty? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A compact surprise ending that rewards rereading for planted clues.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the foreshadowing in this story shape what we understand about friendship tested by duty? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.
4. In the passage that begins "THE policeman on the beat moved up the avenue impressively.", why might Henry have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in "After Twenty Years", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A man waits in a New York doorway to meet his old friend Jimmy Wells, twenty years to the day after they parted. He tells a patrolling policeman about the plan. A man claiming to be Jimmy arrives, but he is a plainclothes officer who arrests the waiting man, 'Silky' Bob, wanted in Chicago. A note…

6. As the opening story, what does "After Twenty Years" set up that the rest of After Twenty Years will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: "Would you turn in a friend who had done something seriously wrong? Why or why not?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with loyalty and duty? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
10. Background: Published in 1906 and collected in The Four Million, which names the ordinary New Yorkers O. Henry wrote about. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "A compact surprise ending that rewards rereading for planted clues." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "After Twenty Years" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about friendship tested by duty? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "After Twenty Years": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to change over time: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Henry need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "After Twenty Years" treats friendship tested by duty with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does After Twenty Years see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve loyalty and duty? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about friendship tested by duty? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask O. Henry about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz

1. How long ago did the two friends agree to meet?
   A. Ten years
   B. Twenty years
   C. Five years
   D. Fifty years
2. Where is the waiting man from now?
   A. The West, Chicago
   B. Boston
   C. London
   D. New Orleans
3. What clue shows the waiting man's wealth?
   A. A diamond scarfpin and watch
   B. A fur coat
   C. A new car
   D. A bag of gold
4. Who was the patrolling policeman?
   A. Jimmy Wells
   B. Bob's brother
   C. A Chicago detective
   D. A stranger
5. Why did Jimmy send someone else to make the arrest?
   A. He could not bring himself to arrest his old friend
   B. He was off duty
   C. He was ordered to
   D. He was afraid

6. In the line “The other, submerged in his overcoat, listened with interest.”, what does “submerged” most nearly mean?
   A. exchanged letters
   B. explained; revealed
   C. too much concern with oneself
   D. sink below the surface; go under or as if under water
7. In the line ““Well, yes, for a time we corresponded,” said the other.”, what does “corresponded” most nearly mean?
   A. explained; revealed
   B. exchanged letters
   C. too much concern with oneself
   D. sink below the surface; go under or as if under water

Answer key: 1. B (Twenty years); 2. A (The West, Chicago); 3. A (A diamond scarfpin and watch); 4. A (Jimmy Wells); 5. A (He could not bring himself to arrest his old friend); 6. D (sink below the surface; go under or as if under water); 7. B (exchanged letters)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “After Twenty Years,” how does Henry show friendship tested by duty? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In After Twenty Years, how does Henry develop the idea of friendship tested by duty? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how After Twenty Years develops the idea of friendship tested by duty. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of After Twenty Years (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of friendship tested by duty. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what After Twenty Years suggests about friendship tested by duty. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and foreshadowing), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how O. Henry uses irony in After Twenty Years to complicate the reader's understanding of friendship tested by duty. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate After Twenty Years within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of friendship tested by duty responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read After Twenty Years alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of friendship tested by duty follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to After Twenty Years and its treatment of friendship tested by duty. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and foreshadowing, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads After Twenty Years as evidence for a larger claim about friendship tested by duty in After Twenty Years. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads After Twenty Years as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of friendship tested by duty. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on After Twenty Years.

SAT-style questions

1. *The man from the West, his egotism enlarged by success, was beginning to outline the history of his career.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “egotism” most nearly mean?

   A. too much concern with oneself

   B. in an uncertain or unsure way

   C. in a gloomy, depressing way

   D. in a way that commands notice or respect

2. *THE policeman on the beat moved up the avenue impressively. The impressiveness was habitual and not for show, for spectators were few. The time was barely 10 o’clock at night, but chilly gusts of wind with a taste of rain in them had well nigh depeopled the streets.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “After Twenty Years”?

   A. Accepting one's place in nature's cycle

B. Friendship tested by duty

C. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

D. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

SAT key: 1. A (too much concern with oneself); 2. B (Friendship tested by duty)

Whole-book test

After Twenty Years: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. How long ago did the two friends agree to meet?
   A. Ten years
   B. Twenty years
   C. Five years
   D. Fifty years
2. Where is the waiting man from now?
   A. The West, Chicago
   B. Boston
   C. London
   D. New Orleans
3. What clue shows the waiting man's wealth?
   A. A diamond scarfpin and watch
   B. A fur coat
   C. A new car
   D. A bag of gold
4. Who was the patrolling policeman?
   A. Jimmy Wells
   B. Bob's brother
   C. A Chicago detective
   D. A stranger
5. Why did Jimmy send someone else to make the arrest?
   A. He could not bring himself to arrest his old friend
   B. He was off duty
   C. He was ordered to
   D. He was afraid
6. In the line “The other, submerged in his overcoat, listened with interest.”, what does “submerged” most nearly mean?
   A. exchanged letters
   B. explained; revealed
   C. too much concern with oneself
   D. sink below the surface; go under or as if under water

7. In the line ““Well, yes, for a time we corresponded,” said the other.”, what does “corresponded” most nearly mean?
   A. explained; revealed
   B. exchanged letters
   C. too much concern with oneself
   D. sink below the surface; go under or as if under water
8. As used in the story (“The other, submerged in his overcoat, listened with interest.”), what does “submerged” mean?
   A. sink below the surface; go under or as if under water
   B. a surrounding or nearby region
   C. in a way that commands notice or respect
   D. explained; revealed
9. As used in the story (““Well, yes, for a time we corresponded,” said the other.”), what does “corresponded” mean?
   A. in a gloomy, depressing way
   B. exchanged letters
   C. sink below the surface; go under or as if under water
   D. a surrounding or nearby region
10. As used in the story (“The man from the West, his egotism enlarged by success, was beginning to outline the history of his career.”), what does “egotism” mean?
    A. in an uncertain or unsure way
    B. exchanged letters
    C. too much concern with oneself
    D. in a gloomy, depressing way
11. As used in the story (“The man from the West unfolded the little piece cf paper handed him.”), what does “unfolded” mean?
    A. in a way that commands notice or respect
    B. too much concern with oneself
    C. in an uncertain or unsure way
    D. explained; revealed
12. As used in the story (“The vicinity was one that kept early hours.”), what does “vicinity” mean?
    A. a surrounding or nearby region
    B. sink below the surface; go under or as if under water
    C. explained; revealed
    D. in a way that commands notice or respect

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how loyalty and duty develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how change over time develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

3. Explain how friendship develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (loyalty and duty, change over time, friendship) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. B (Twenty years); 2. A (The West, Chicago); 3. A (A diamond scarfpin and watch); 4. A (Jimmy Wells); 5. A (He could not bring himself to arrest his old friend); 6. D (sink below the surface; go under or as if under water); 7. B (exchanged letters); 8. A (sink below the surface; go under or as if under water); 9. B (exchanged letters); 10. C (too much concern with oneself); 11. D (explained; revealed); 12. A (a surrounding or nearby region)

Essay assignments

Essay: Loyalty and duty

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what After Twenty Years teaches about loyalty and duty. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops loyalty and duty in After Twenty Years. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops loyalty and duty across After Twenty Years. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of After Twenty Years (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of loyalty and duty. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of loyalty and duty in After Twenty Years. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in After Twenty Years (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of loyalty and duty, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places After Twenty Years's treatment of loyalty and duty in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on loyalty and duty in After Twenty Years that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on loyalty and duty in After Twenty Years. Name your critical

method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about loyalty and duty in After Twenty Years, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on loyalty and duty in After Twenty Years, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Change over time

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what After Twenty Years teaches about change over time. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops change over time in After Twenty Years. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops change over time across After Twenty Years. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of After Twenty Years (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of change over time. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of change over time in After Twenty Years. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in After Twenty Years (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of change over time, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places After Twenty Years's treatment of change over time in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on change over time in After Twenty Years that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on change over time in After Twenty Years. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about change over time in After Twenty Years, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on change over time in After Twenty Years, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Friendship

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what After Twenty Years teaches about friendship. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops friendship in After Twenty Years. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops friendship across After Twenty Years. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of After Twenty Years (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of friendship. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of friendship in After Twenty Years. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in After Twenty Years (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of friendship, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places After Twenty Years's treatment of friendship in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on friendship in After Twenty Years that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on friendship in After Twenty Years. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about friendship in After Twenty Years, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on friendship in After Twenty Years, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.